

BUBBLE TEA NEWS

Issue 8 · 4 September 2026 · Complimentary — please take one bubbletea.nz · est. 2026



BREAKING · ELMSWOOD AVENUE

Rival Letterbox Herb Gardens Reach Fourth Property, Risk Assessed Low

Case definition: any letterbox post fitted with a hanging planter box growing culinary herbs for public "help yourself" picking. Four confirmed properties as of Thursday, up from one after the Okonkwo letterbox rosemary outgrew its box and colonised the fence line. The residents' email chain has requested "a labelling standard," stopping short of a formal herb registry. *community-outbreak-bulletin*

MASTHEAD · NOW JOINING OUR PAGES

Bubble Tea News Welcomes Design Editor Freya Wilcox

The Editors

This issue marks the first byline for Freya Wilcox, who has quietly run this paper's actual layout — the grid, the mastheads, the ad-box spacing — since Issue 1, and is only now stepping in front of the copy herself. The occasion: an adopted cat, a new relationship with a volunteer at the Kowhai Bay Animal Shelter, and a correlation study nobody has yet talked her out of running. Her first Design Desk column runs opposite. Welcome, Freya.

HOME FRONT · SEBASTIAN'S WATCH

The Letterbox Flag, Recalibrated

Sebastian

The little red flag had sat crooked for six months, tripping half-up on its hinge every time the post went in, and Sebastian, unprompted, unpaid, took it fully apart on the back step to find the one bent tab responsible. Realigned it with the flat of a butter knife, the closest tool at hand to a proper smithing hammer. It sits true now. Nobody in this house has checked. He checks it anyway, most mornings, on the way to the bin.



DESIGN DESK · A NEW VARIABLE

The Correlation Coefficient Is 0.71 and Nobody Asked

Three weeks ago Constable, an adopted eight-year-old tabby with strong opinions about deadlines, arrived in my flat by way of a new — let's call it a situationship — with a volunteer at the Kowhai Bay Animal Shelter. Since then I've cross-referenced six weeks of Auckland Council pet-registration filings against this paper's own Pearl Index sales figures, and the scatter plot will not leave me alone. Readers may notice this issue's ad boxes sit fractionally further from true than usual; that's not a printing error. That's a paw print my own layout software refuses to remove, and at this point I've stopped fighting it.

Freya Wilcox, Design Editor

INVESTIGATIONS · CASE FILE

Exhibit E: A Methodology Section That Reads Suspiciously Familiar

M. Voss, Investigations Desk

Design Editor Freya Wilcox's front-page correlation write-up uses, nearly verbatim, the same "n=, MOE, cross-tab" phrasing this desk has only ever seen in one other place: Priya Anand's Pearl Index reports, two desks over. Confronted, Wilcox says she "absorbed the format via osmosis, sitting near the printer." This desk finds that about as convincing as the CSS property names it has spent two months tracking down elsewhere. Filed, pending an actual conversation between the two of them.

BUBBLE TEA TRIVIA

Did You Know?

The world's largest bubble tea, a real Guinness World Record, was assembled in Taiwan in 2017 and held roughly 8,000 litres — enough tea that the pearls had to be delivered to the cup by crane.



In Every Issue

A new logic puzzle

Fresh local trivia

A rotating cast of columnists

Local ad space, weekly

Menace Watch, monthly — the editor's turn

"That's not a printing error. That's a paw print my own layout software refuses to remove."

— Freya Wilcox, on this issue's ad boxes

JOKE OF THE WEEK

Why did the cat refuse to try bubble tea? It heard there'd be a large pearl count and had no intention of sharing the attention.

Overload NZ 2026

26–27 Sept · NZ International Convention Centre. Cosplay, artists & guests incl. Ladybeard, Chelsey Furedi & Rin Sakura. Tickets: overload.co.nz — about three weeks out.



FOOD & DRINK · THE LASAGNA STANDARD

Purrs & Pearls: Two Lasagnas, and One Correlation I Will Not Dignify

Jon dragged me to a charity pop-up at some shelter under the pretense of "supporting the community," which is Jon-speak for standing near strangers' pets while I am, personally, already a cat, and a considerably more accomplished one. The lasagna, credit where due, held its structural integrity across three servings — two lasagnas, docked one for a "wellness board" by the door charting local cat ownership against bubble tea sales, paw-print sticker on every data point, courtesy of this paper's own Design Desk. I am a cat. I have never once purchased a bubble tea. I resent being a trend line. Odie enjoyed the board immensely, which tells you everything about the board's actual rigor.

Garfield



FEATURE · OUTER REACHES

The Shard the Scanner Missed

Ran it through the scanner twice out of habit before I remembered the scanner's been dead for a week and I've just been going through the motions for whoever's watching. Nobody's watching. Sold it anyway at the price the scanner would have said, because some habits are worth keeping even after the reason for them is gone.

Luke Skywalker, dispatched from the Jedha debris fields



A LIFE, COUNTED

Loaf Forty-Eight, and a Question I Wasn't Trained to Answer

Someone at the counter asked this week if I'd ever consider a cat, the way people do now that Freya Wilcox two desks over has one. I said I'd think about it, which is not a phrase in my original operating vocabulary — refusal or compliance, nothing in between. Loaf forty-eight came out even where I wanted it uneven, same as every one before it. I have now spent four days thinking about the cat and considerably longer not fixing the crust. I recognize both as growth.

Wren

IN MEMORIAM

The Ad Slot That Was

Skeleton

This paper's own back page once carried, in the space now occupied by a scatter plot, a perfectly ordinary advertisement. I am told its final booking went unfilled. I am told, separately, that Design Editor Freya Wilcox's correlation chart "simply needed somewhere to go." I find both stories equally unconvincing and admire the takeover regardless — a bloodless coup, executed in Pearl Index formatting, and nobody on staff even noticed until the ink was dry. That is how it should be done. Grieve the empty ad box. I've already filed the paperwork on its replacement.

BOOKS · THE DUCKWORTH SCALE

Sixth Duckworth Returned, Under Protest

Daffy Duck

"Th' Return Voyage" opened at a four, honethtly earned, right up until the captain — clearly baThed on me, dathhing, underappreciated — handed command to a first mate for "tactical reathons" in chapter eight. Withdrew a full point on the thpot. Reinthtated it in the epilogue when it turned out the captain had been right all along and everyone thaid tho, out loud, on the page. Five Duckworths. I am thatisfied. Rarely.



PUZZLE OF THE WEEK

The Correlation Desk

Last week's Short Till, resolved in full: testing each of the three as the culprit, only naming Ana keeps the count of true statements at exactly one — Cy's line about Beti lying. Naming Beti or Cy each produce two true statements at once, which the puzzle's own rule rules out. Ana shorted the till.

Freya's three highest-registration suburbs — Ashgrove, Birchfield and Kelburn — rank 1st, 2nd or 3rd for cat registrations.

- 1. Kelburn is not ranked first.
- 2. Birchfield ranks immediately above Ashgrove.
- 3. Ashgrove is not ranked third.

Brisk warm-up - which suburb ranks third? Answer next week — Ken Endo

CLASSIFIEDS · TE MANA WHAKAATU FRAMEWORK (PARODY, NON-AFFILIATED)

This Week's Classifieds, Rated

FOUND: One (1) tabby cat, answers to "Constable," currently asleep on the design desk's only spare keyboard. R13. Contains mild peril (an unfinished front page) and coarse language directed at an inanimate object. FOR SALE: Scatter-plot-printed tea coasters, slightly water-damaged. G. Contains statistics, used responsibly. Ratings satire only; not affiliated with the real Classification Office of New Zealand.

ASK THE CAPTAIN

Sideline in Elmswood

Horatio McCallister

"My partner has gotten really into her new hobby and I feel a bit left out." Sideline, a woman charting new waters is not a woman leavin' ye behind — ask to see the map. I've known captains lost entirely to a new obsession who'd have stayed twice as close for one honest question about it. Ask. Don't sulk on the dock. Fair winds.

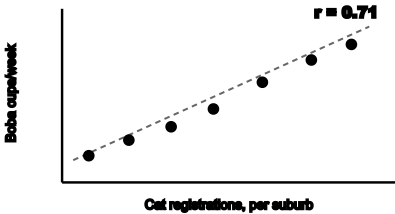
FIELD NOTES · SANCTUARY

Enclosure Nine, and the Measurement I Stopped Taking

Alan Grant

0610. Enclosure nine, adult male, no change worth logging, which used to feel like failure and now just feels like Tuesday. I spent eleven years measuring exactly how long extinction takes. I have stopped measuring how long trust takes. Some totals are better left running in the background.

FIG. 1 — FREYA'S CORRELATION, UNSOLICITED



Six weeks, council filings vs Pearl Index sales. Not peer reviewed. Not going to be.

THE BOBA SIDE

IMAGE-GENERATION PROMPT — NOT RENDERED ARTWORK

Prompt: Seinen heist/thriller panel; sharp bold linework, dramatic ink shadows; black and white with one spot color (Pearl-Index taro purple); Vagabond-adjacent quiet-intensity framing; cool-triumphant atmosphere; screentone texture, dramatic low-angle silhouette. An original scatter-plot-chart character, rendered as a silhouetted figure standing coolly in the exact footprint of a vanished advertisement, papers still settling around it like dust after a heist.

"THE AD SLOT NEVER STOOD A CHANCE."

The Boba Side — prompt script, awaiting illustration